

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 11~06~2026
-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-
"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You
Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing
of other topics in the main exam.



Taiwan Tests HIMARS Rockets

Taiwan's High Mobility Artillery Rocket Systems (HIMARS) during a live military exercise, which simulates an enemy invasion, in Taichung, Taiwan, on Wednesday. REUTERS

TAIWAN'S MILITARY Wednesday fired its new HIMARS rocket system, simulating an attack on an invading Chinese force and demonstrating its "shoot-and-scoot" ability to evade counterstrikes.

THE MILITARY said the drill was to demonstrate the HIMARS' mobility and ability to "shoot-and-scoot" — withdrawing after firing to avoid enemy radar — so as to "greatly improve battlefield survivability".

HIMARS IS one of Ukraine's main strike systems and has been used multiple times during the war with Russia. With a range of 300 kms it could strike targets in China's southeastern province. REUTERS

● PRESIDENT RUTO OF KENYA ACCUSED OF BOWING TO U.S. INTERESTS, RISKING KENYAN LIVES BY LETTING AMERICAN PATIENTS INTO THE COUNTRY WHEN THEY ARE BEING BARRED FROM THE UNITED STATES

Ebola unit for infected Americans sparks fury, protests, political crisis in Kenya

Matthew Mpoke Bigg
& Eric Schmitt
Nairobi, Washington, June 10

THE US plan to open an Ebola quarantine facility in Kenya was meant to help contain the outbreak by isolating American patients exposed to the virus. Instead, it has caused an outbreak of violence and political rancor, with hundreds of Kenyans taking to the streets in protest. Last month, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said that no Ebola patients would be allowed to enter the United States after the World Health Organization announced a dangerous outbreak in Congo. Rubio later appeared to soften that stance.

US government officials later told reporters that the Trump administration planned to send to Kenya all US citizens exposed to the virus, rather than bring them home. The Americans would be observed and treated at a 50-bed quarantine unit exclusively for them, set up at Laikipia Air Base in central Kenya, the officials said. The outcry in Kenya has been fierce. Hundreds of people have marched through the streets of Nanyuki, the town closest to the air base, to protest the facility. Police have used tear gas to disperse crowds, and at least three protesters have been shot and killed, according to the

Kenya Human Rights Commission. The Kenyan police did not respond to a request for comment Tuesday. Critics of President William Ruto of Kenya accuse him of bowing to US interests and risking Kenyan lives by letting exposed American patients into the country when they are being barred from the United States. Others have asked why Kenya, which has never recorded an Ebola case, would agree to host the unit when US government officials say Kenyans would be excluded from receiving treatment there. "We are utterly disgusted by the government's apparent willingness to trade national



People gather to protest a US-backed Ebola quarantine plan in Nanyuki, Kenya, on Wednesday. REUTERS

biosecurity and the lives of its citizens for foreign aid," the Kenya Medical Practitioners,

Pharmacists and Dentists Union said in a statement. The full details of the agree-

ment between the United States and Kenya have not been made public. But a US official told *The New York Times* that talks were still continuing when US government officials told reporters about the plan. In a comment to the *Times*, the State Department said it planned to provide transportation for Americans to the Ebola unit but made no reference to whether Kenyans would be admitted. Kenya's High Court temporarily suspended the unit from opening last week, after a legal challenge brought by the Katiba Institute, a civil society organization. The court ordered the Kenyan government

to disclose the terms of its deal with the United States by Tuesday. It also said it would set a date for the next hearing on the case June 23. Despite the court suspension and the protests, a second US official said that US Africa Command was still at work building out the unit at the air base as recently as Saturday, and that around 300 US troops from Djibouti, Europe and the US were helping to erect large tents and set up specialized medical equipment to treat Ebola patients. The official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss operational matters, said that the facility could

eventually hold up to 250 patients and that the State Department was coordinating with several Americans who are seeking to leave Congo, but whose exposure to the virus has not yet been determined. The US military has continued the work on the unit because Ruto's government has not told it to stop, the official said. Work on the facility was on hold Tuesday because of the protests, the official said. Dr Mehmet Oz, a top federal health official in the United States, told journalists at the White House last week that the State Department would "be able to work out something with Kenya." NYT

TECH

In AI giants’ listing plans, questions over valuations



Soumyaendra Barik

WITHIN DAYS of each other, two of the world’s most closely watched artificial intelligence (AI) companies in Anthropic and OpenAI have confidentially filed paperwork for public listings in the US, setting the stage for what could be some of the largest and most hotly anticipated technology initial public offerings (IPOs) in history. Elon Musk’s SpaceX is also gearing up for what could be the biggest IPO ever attempted, in terms of valuation.

The offerings are likely to draw intense interest from investors globally who, until now, have largely watched the AI boom from the sidelines. Much of the value created by the rise of generative AI has accrued to private investors, venture capital firms and strategic backers such as big technology companies. Public listings by the companies building the foundational models themselves would offer retail and institutional investors a rare opportunity to directly participate in what many see as the defining technological shift of the decade, even as concerns over a bubble around AI remain.

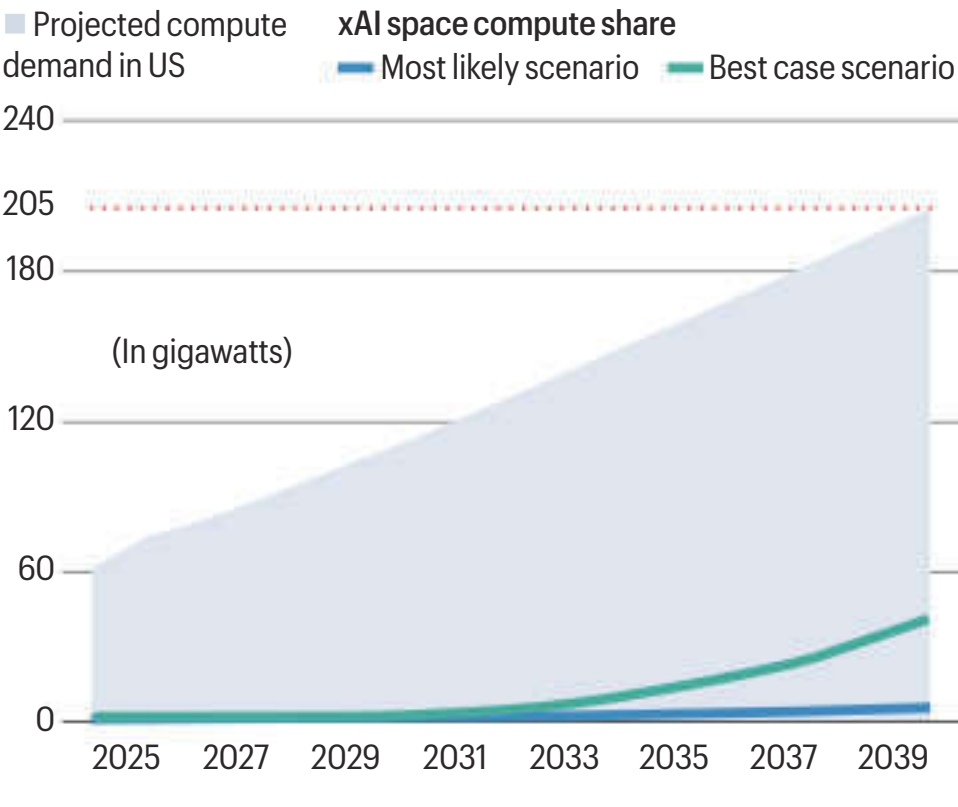
Anthropic, fresh off a \$65-billion funding round that valued it at roughly \$965 billion, has already begun the process, while OpenAI has followed with its own confidential filing and is targeting a valuation that could touch the \$1-trillion mark. SpaceX is seeking an even greater valuation, around \$1.75 trillion.

Yet, alongside the excitement lies a growing debate over whether private market valuations have raced ahead of business fundamentals. With investors pouring unprecedented sums into AI and frontier technology companies, some analysts have cautioned that expectations embedded in current valuations may prove hard to justify.

Here’s why some are cautious around lofty AI-linked valuations, especially for SpaceX, and how Indian investors — those who are willing to bet on the touted AI gains — can participate in these upcoming IPOs.

SPACEX’S SHARE OF THE PIE

Estimates by investment research company Morningstar show that, SpaceX could control anywhere between 4% to 21% of the world’s global computing capacity by 2039, depending on how some of its offerings fare



The headquarters of SpaceX in Washington DC. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Concerns around ‘AI-washing’

Analysts at the investment research company Morningstar have valued SpaceX at roughly \$780 billion — less than half its IPO target — arguing that investors may be placing overly optimistic bets on future growth and unproven businesses linked to AI. Morningstar has also questioned the economics of some of the company’s AI ambitions and said the market may be getting ahead of fundamentals.

“We see a wide range of possibilities around the newly acquired AI business and find its economic moat indeterminate, and it also poses a material threat of value destruction to the company, which limits our overall economic moat rating to narrow... Our discounted cash flow valuation of SpaceX is \$780 billion, about 48% below its private market valuation, including a wide range of probability-weighted scenarios for the AI business,” Morningstar said in a blog.

If the company achieves the valuation target of about \$1.75 trillion, it would surpass even Saudi Aramco’s 2019 debut as the world’s largest IPO.

Founded in 2002, SpaceX has evolved

Record valuations

Anthropic is fresh off a \$65-billion funding round that valued it at \$965 billion.

OpenAI is targeting a valuation that could touch the \$1-trillion mark.

SpaceX is seeking a valuation of \$1.75 trillion.

Anthropic, OpenAI and SpaceX are eyeing some of the largest IPOs ever. But have their valuations raced ahead of business fundamentals?

that investors were paying a steep premium for a company that had yet to prove it could scale production or generate sustained profits.

Yet Tesla ultimately justified much of that optimism by reshaping the global automotive industry and becoming one of the world’s most valuable companies.

The key difference, though, is that Tesla’s valuation debate centred on a tangible product and a clearly identifiable market opportunity. In SpaceX’s case, critics argue that a significant portion of its proposed valuation rests on more speculative assumptions around Starlink’s future growth and the economics of AI-linked businesses.

How to invest in SpaceX IPO, other foreign IPOs

Indian retail investors can participate in SpaceX’s upcoming IPO, but the process isn’t as straightforward as investing through a demat account in the Indian stock market.

According to a blog post by the stock trading platform Upstox: “Indian residents cannot directly participate in this IPO. However, they may do so through their overseas brokerage accounts funded under the RBI’s Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS).” Under the Reserve Bank of India’s (RBI’s) LRS, Indians can freely remit up to \$250,000 per financial year for permissible capital and current account transactions, including for investments in foreign IPOs. Potential investors can set up an account with one of the many overseas brokerage platforms.

Upstox noted that while Indian investors can participate in the IPO, “the chances of allotment of SpaceX shares through the initial public offering are low”.

It is always a challenge for a foreign retail investor to get a US IPO allotment, because most of the US IPO allotments are typically made to institutional investors, the trading platform said. Reports suggest that nearly 30% of the offering will be earmarked for retail investors, with the rest reserved for institutional investors.

An IPO, however, is not the only way to buy shares of the company, and investors may purchase the stock once it is publicly listed.

HISTORY

How Birsa Munda helped define Adivasi identity, rights

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, June 10

ON JUNE 9, the death anniversary of the iconic Adivasi leader and freedom fighter Birsa Munda, several tribal organisations in Jharkhand took a pledge to “protect his legacy”. This pledge came amid the fresh demands for “delisting” — removing tribal converts to Christianity or Islam from the Scheduled Tribes (ST) list — that have reignited a long-running debate over Adivasi identity. The latest delisting demand was made last month at a tribal gathering attended by Union Home Minister Amit Shah in Delhi.

The tribal organisations in Jharkhand said during the pledge event that Birsa Munda’s vision was rooted in Adivasi identity, sovereignty and land rights, and accused right-wing groups of attempting to reinterpret that outlook.

So what did Birsa stand for? More than 125 years after his death, here’s a look at the tribal leader’s life, beliefs and legacy.

Who was Birsa Munda?

Birsa Munda is one of the most influential figures in the history of the Chotanagpur plateau, the mineral-rich region spanning Jharkhand and adjoining states.

Revered by many as “Dharti Aba” (father of the Earth), he is remembered for

leading the Ulgulan, or the “Great Tumult” — a movement against colonial rule and “diku” (non-tribal outsider) zamindars amid the growing encroachment on Adivasi land and cultural institutions in the closing years of the 19th century.

Birsa’s influence, however, extended beyond the borders of the current Jharkhand state to the remote villages of Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and more. In his seminal study *Birsa Munda and His Movement*, historian K S Singh described Birsa as a religious reformer, social mobiliser and political leader who transformed the Munda tribal society.

Adivasi historian Joseph Bara similarly argues that Birsa cannot be understood merely as the leader of an agrarian uprising. Rather, he articulated a broader vision of Adivasi identity, autonomy, land rights, religion and self-rule (known as *disum*).

Bara notes that his prominence in mainstream political and public discourse grew significantly during the decades preceding and following the creation of Jharkhand in 2000.

From resistance to statehood

The Ulgulan, led by Birsa Munda, reached its climax at Dombari Buru, a hill in a Khunti village, in January 1899. This was where thousands of Birsa’s followers gathered to assert their rights over land and

What is the Chotanagpur Tenancy Act?

● The CNT Act was enacted by the British in 1908 after decades of Adivasi resistance (including Birsa Munda’s uprising) to protect customary land rights in Chotanagpur region.

● The central objective was preventing the transfer of Adivasi land to non-Adivasis and legally recognising traditional land tenure systems.

● The Act remains one of the strongest safeguards for tribal land in Jharkhand.

challenge British authority, according to historian K S Singh.

The British forces eventually surrounded the hill and fired into the crowd. In Adivasi memory, this was a massacre that killed hundreds, though official records estimate a much lower toll. Birsa was arrested and died in Ranchi Jail on June 9, 1900.

While the British may have crushed the uprising, Dombari Buru became a symbol of Adivasi resistance.

The episode compelled the colonial administration to initiate land reforms that culminated in legal recognition of Khuntkatti rights and later the Chotanagpur Tenancy (CNT) Act, 1908. Khuntkatti was the traditional Munda system of collective land ownership and governance. Under the system, the descendants of the original settlers who cleared forests and established a village, known as Khuntkattidars, held collective rights over the village territory.

Bara writes that the aspiration for Adivasi self-governance articulated during Ulgulan was later channelled into the movement for a separate Jharkhand under Jaipal Singh Munda in the mid-1900s.

Religious views

According to family accounts shared by Budhram Munda, a descendant of the family, Birsa spent parts of his early childhood at his uncle’s village before studying

at missionary schools in Chaibasa.

Budhram Munda said that Birsa’s association with missionary education ended after a disagreement with church authorities over remarks about the Munda tribal community. After distancing himself from Christianity, Birsa came under the influence of Vaishnavism for some time.

“He was jailed in 1885 for two years and, eventually, after being released, he started preaching his teachings towards life and nature...,” said Budhram Munda.

These teachings created a religious movement that came to be known as the Birsait faith, different from Sarnaim (the traditional tribal faith), Christianity and Hinduism. His followers attribute various miracles to him and consider him a messiah, referring to him as “Bhagwan” and the aforementioned “Dharti Aba”.

Budhram Munda said: “Bhagwan Birsa never targeted any particular religion. He opposed both the outsiders from the caste society who were appointed as zamindars, and the Christian missionaries, as he saw them as part of the same system of exploitation,” he said. Opposing the demand for delisting of Christian tribals from the ST list, Budhram Munda said that descendants of Birsa’s family have followed Christianity for generations. He argued that Adivasi identity is determined by ancestry and community, not religion.

INFRASTRUCTURE

Zojila Tunnel: The challenge of digging through the Himalayas

Sabab Virani
Sonamarg, June 10

THE BREAKTHROUGH of the Zojila Tunnel, a 13-km passage being carved through the Himalayas at an altitude of 11,578 feet, is a major milestone for one of India’s most challenging infrastructure projects. But unlike tunnels bored through relatively stable rock formations elsewhere, excavation in the Himalayas comes with a unique set of geological and environmental risks.

Building a Himalayan tunnel

Multiple reasons make tunnelling through the Himalayas a challenging feat. The altitude lends to difficult working conditions. So do the temperatures, which fall to as low as -30°C. Geologist Arnold Dix said that working in these conditions is difficult for both workers and combustion engine machines. The harsh winters often bring along avalanches, which can be fatal. Additionally, the rock strata in the Himalayas are highly variable, even differing metre to metre, said Dix. This means a long list of surprises lie in store for the engineers as they drill through. Loose rock, boulders, water ingress: the rock formations can be delicate and susceptible to disasters. Each variation requires a different treatment for structural integrity.

Particularly risky

The Himalaya range is a relatively new mountain range, making it far more tectonically active. “To a geologist,” said Dix, “the Himalayas are ocean floors that have been pushed upwards.”

This rock strata the engineers can encounter can be soft rock, characteristic

of a sea bed, to boulders and everything in between. The way the mountain has formed could have left cavities and cracks. A lot of water — even up to an ocean’s worth — is stored in the mountains. Due to its age, there are sheer zones where there is higher strain on the rock and tunnelling can lead to instability.

Methods of safe excavation

The Zojila tunnel was excavated using the New Austrian Tunneling Method, tailor-made for such conditions. The method involves selective blasting of the rock, followed by securing the tunnel wall with shotcrete (sprayed concrete) and rock bolts. The excavation is done in two steps, wherein the top half of the tunnel is excavated first, followed by the bottom half.

Besides the water stored in them, the mountains have melting snow coming through as well. Depending upon the level of water ingress, engineers will fit pipes and allow the water to drain out in a gradual manner so as to not allow water pressure to build up in the mountain, which could potentially lead to a collapse or flooding.

Cracks in the rock formation will alter the number, size, and spacing of the rock bolts, while the shotcrete glues the rocks together. Even the tunnel’s alignment can be tweaked to bypass a mountain’s weak segment and skirt around it. The tunnel’s shape and configuration is also moulded as per site conditions. “It’s like conducting an operation without anesthesia. This is why tunnelling in the Himalayas has to be done slowly and carefully,” said Dix.

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IMMIGRATION

Trump’s \$100,000 H-1B fee scrapped, but some Indians have paid the price

Vidheesha Kuntamalla & Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, June 10

A US FEDERAL judge’s decision to strike down President Donald Trump’s controversial \$100,000 fee on new H-1B visas will come as some relief to employers, but many foreign workers have already faced much of its brunt. Last week, US District Judge Leo Sorokin of Massachusetts ruled that the fee was unlawful, concluding that it functioned as a tax — something the President lacks the authority to impose without Congressional approval.

What is the H-1B programme and how did the fee affect it?

The H-1B visa allows US employers to hire foreign nationals in specific occupations or roles that require at a minimum a bachelor’s degree and a body of specialised knowledge. The US Congress has capped approvals at 65,000 per year for most private employers, with an additional 20,000 for holders of advanced degrees. Universities,

nonprofit research organisations and government research bodies are exempt from this cap and can file petitions at any time.

Before the \$100,000 proclamation, the petition fees ranged from \$960 to \$7,595. While signing the proclamation to increase the fee in September 2025, Trump had cited concerns that the H-1B programme had been used to replace American workers with foreign labour at lower wages, particularly in STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics) fields.

Why did the court strike down the fee?

The central question was whether the \$100,000 payment was a legitimate immigration penalty or an unlawful tax.

The administration said the fee was a restriction on entry as the overall revenue collected fell after the proclamation took effect.

The court disagreed, stating that hiring H-1B workers is lawful conduct and that the payment did not operate as a penalty for unlawful behaviour. Instead, it generated revenue and therefore functioned as a tax.

It said that “purpose and effect are different” and added that “every \$100,000 payment made pursuant to the Policy does raise revenue. That is indisputable.”

The US Constitution gives Congress the power to impose and collect taxes. While Congress can delegate that to the executive branch, the court said it must do so clearly.

The court also cited the Supreme Court’s ruling this year in which tariffs imposed under a separate statute were struck down on the same logic. Robert Bray, a retired Immigration Officer with the United States Citizenship and Immigration Services’ Fraud Detection and National Security division, told *The Indian Express* that once the court characterised the payment as a tax, much of the government’s defence collapsed.

Why is the ruling important?

Indian citizens receive more than 70% of all H-1B visas issued annually and dominate the technology, engineering, healthcare and consulting sectors that rely heavily on the programme.

Washington DC-based immigration attorney Rajiv Khanna told *The Indian Express* that the ruling restores predictability to a system that many workers felt had become increasingly unstable.

“There is a system in place and that system cannot be disturbed at the whim or fancy of a government that decides matters without any empirical evidence of what will work, what will not work, and what they are trying to correct,” he said.

Bray described the ruling as potentially precedent-setting because it limits how administrations can impose immigration-related charges without a Congressional nod.

How has the fee affected workers?

While the court ruling is being celebrated by many immigration advocates, some lawyers say damage may already have been done. Asel Williams, a founding immigration attorney at New York City-based Williams Law, told *The Indian Express*: “Indian professionals on H-1B and STEM OPT status have already felt the impact of the

\$100,000 H-1B fee introduced last year.” OPT, or Optional Practical Training, allows international students on F-1 visas to work in the US after graduation in jobs related to their field of study.

According to Williams, many employers became reluctant to sponsor foreign workers once the fee was announced. “Fewer companies are willing to sponsor Indian nationals, terminations are rising, and I am receiving a growing number of inquiries from laid-off H-1B holders with only 60 days to secure new employment,” she said.

Williams said that immigration restrictions have coincided with broader technological disruptions in the labour market. “These layoffs are being driven by a combination of AI displacement and increasingly restrictive H-1B policies. The damage to Indian H-1B holders and STEM OPT workers has in large part already been done,” she said. Similarly, Bray noted that the fee appeared to suppress demand for new H-1B sponsorships. “The number of H-1Bs originating in other countries was re-

duced exponentially,” he said.

The consequences were particularly severe for workers who had already obtained H-1B status but later lost their jobs. “For people who got laid off on an H-1B and had to leave the US to come back, they would have had to pay \$100,000,” Khanna said.

What now for H-1B holders?

A legal challenge from the government is expected. Khanna said the administration generally has about 30 days to file an appeal and could simultaneously seek a stay of the ruling. “If the stay is granted, then this ruling does not come into effect until the appeal is decided, which can take a few months.”

Williams urged foreign workers to avoid assuming that the ruling resolves immigration uncertainties. “I recommend H-1B holders avoid international travel,” she said. “The court ruling does not automatically make it easier to obtain an H-1B visa through consular processing. Both the US Department of State and DHS retain discretion to deny any H-1B petition.”

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Human contribution to global warming highest ever in 2025, says study

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, June 10

AT A time when global political attention to climate change appears to be receding, a new assessment has confirmed earlier estimates that 2025 was the third warmest year on record. Importantly, this annual study, called the Indicators of Global Climate Change or IGCC, found that the contribution of human activities to the overall warming observed in 2025 was possibly the highest ever.

The IGCC study, first published in 2023, is the work of an independent international

E. EXPLAINED

‘35% by 2035’

The ongoing climate meet in Germany has proposed a global commitment to ensure that electricity accounts for at least 35% of final energy consumption by 2035. Currently, it accounts for 20% of global energy consumption. This is a key step towards the transition from fossil fuels.

group of climate scientists which
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Urea prices crash in latest import tender as China partially lifts restrictions

Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, June 10

IN A relief for India, the state-owned National Fertilizers Limited’s (NFL) latest tender for import of 1.7 million tonnes (mt) of urea has received landed price (cost plus freight) quotes

of \$444.9-449.3 per tonne. This is less than half the winning landed price bids of \$935-959 per tonne for an earlier tender issued by Indian Potash Limited (IPL) for import of 2.5 mt. Industry sources attributed the lower price quotes in the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Urea

latest tender mainly to China is-suing export quotas for urea. “China partially lifting export restrictions has not only eased soaring global prices, but also come at the right time with kharif (monsoon) crop plantings underway,” a source said.

The NFL tender, issued on May 27 and opened on June 8, received bids for 6.25 mt. That included 3.17 mt for supplying to the country’s eastern ports and 3.08 mt to the western ports. The lowest bids were at \$444.9 per tonne, by Aditya Birla Global Trading for delivery to the eastern coast, and at \$449.3 per tonne by Ameropa Asia for delivery to the western coast.

The previous IPL tender for import of 2.5 mt, issued on April 4 and opened on April 15, received offers for over 5.9 mt. But the suppliers agreed for de-

liveries to the western coast at \$935 per tonne and to the eastern coast at \$959 per tonne.

In March, China had restricted export of the nitrogenous fertiliser following the supply shock from the Iran war and closure of the Strait of Hormuz, through which India imported a record 11.17 mt of urea in 2025-26 (April-March) valued at \$5.16 billion, up from 6.91 mt (\$2.38 billion) in 2024-25. Of the total 11.17 mt imports, China alone accounted for 2.23 mt, followed by Oman (1.91 mt), Russia (1.64 mt), Qatar (0.95 mt), Indonesia and Saudi Arabia (0.65 mt each), United Arab Emirates and Finland (0.46 mt each) and Nigeria (0.45 mt).

The NFL tender had specified that the shipments for the contracted quantities should leave the loading ports by July 20. This would allow the shipments to land by August, in time for use by farmers in the later part of the kharif season.

Global warming

includes several contributors to the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) that produces periodic reports on the state of climate change, which are considered the most authoritative word on the subject.

The latest IGCC study said average global temperatures in 2025 were about 1.39 degree Celsius higher than the average of 1850-1900 baseline. Of the total increase, it said 1.37 degree Celsius was due to human activities, primarily greenhouse gas emissions, while the rest could be the result of natural variations in climate systems.

The IGCC study, published in the peer-reviewed open access journal called Earth System Science Data, confirms the earlier estimate of the World Meteorological Organisation (WMO) which, in January this year, had said that 2025 was likely to emerge as the third warmest year, after 2024 and 2023. WMO had said the average glo-

bal temperatures in 2025 were likely to be 1.44 degree Celsius above the 1850-1900 baseline.

The warmest-ever year, 2024, was about 1.55 degree Celsius hotter than the 1850-1900 baseline. That year, human activities had contributed about 1.36 degree Celsius of warming, according to the IGCC study for 2024, the rest being attributed to natural variations. The year 2023 was about 1.45 degree Celsius warmer than 1850-1900 baseline. Human contribution that year was assessed to be about 1.31 degree Celsius.

For 2025, the contribution of human activities to global warming is possibly the highest ever, but the scale of natural variations in climate differ from year to year. 2025 happened to be a La Nina year, a year in which the equatorial Pacific Ocean, off the western coast of South America, was cooler than normal. La Nina is known to have a general cool-

ing effect on the planet. This could have been the reason why the year, despite the potentially record-breaking contribution of human-induced warming, was slightly cooler than 2024 and 2023.

The IGCC study said human-induced warming had been increasing at the rate of about 0.27 degree Celsius per decade, as a result of record levels of greenhouse gas emissions. It found that greenhouse gas emissions had reached 56.8 billion tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent in 2025, an all-time high.

It said the world could emit no more than 130 billion tonnes of additional carbon dioxide from the start of 2026, if it entertained any hopes of restricting global rise in temperatures to within 1.5 degree Celsius from the 1850-1900 baseline. At current rate of emissions, this ‘carbon budget’ would be exhausted in less than three years.

The IGCC study is being released in a week when countries are assembled in Bonn, Germany, for the annual mid-year climate talks. The discussions

are centred mainly around ways to increase the ambition of climate action which has suffered a major blow due to the withdrawal of the United States from the 2015 Paris Agreement last year. Global climate action has been unable to keep pace with the requirement to significantly cut greenhouse gas emissions in the near term.

The findings of the IGCC study are a further reminder to the rapidly rising global temperatures. Just last month, a WMO study said there was a 91 per cent chance that at least one of the next five years, between 2026 and 2030, would break the 1.5 degree Celsius threshold, just like 2024 did. It further said that there was a 75 per cent possibility that the average temperature of this five-year period also exceeded 1.5 degree Celsius level from the 1850-1900 baseline.

This year, a strong El Nino is predicted to develop in the equatorial Pacific Ocean. This year’s El Nino is expected to persist not just through the end of the year, but possibly also continue into early next year.

Pandemic preparedness is deeper, must become broader



SHAHID JAMEEL

Global preparedness remains strongest against crises the world has repeatedly confronted — Ebola — and weakest against novel events such as the Hantavirus

THE MONTHS of April and May in England, where I now live, herald spring after a long, dark and wet winter. Back home in India, they signal the onset of summer. Yet, despite the colours of spring, these months revive painful memories of 2021, when Covid brought death and despair to India. Everyone lost someone. I did, too. Five years later, the world is confronting two very different infectious disease outbreaks. Hantavirus infections emerged aboard MV *Hondius* in early April, with 11 suspected cases and three deaths. Ebola resurfaced in Central Africa and continues to spread. These offer important benchmarks for assessing our preparedness five years after Covid.

Let us first consider early detection, surveillance and public-health infrastructure. In the case of Ebola, authorities did relatively well in early detection and surveillance, largely because the world has spent decades preparing for its recurrence. In contrast, the Hantavirus exposed surveillance gaps during unusual, low-frequency zoonotic outbreaks in complex international settings like cruise ships, especially when the pathogen is unexpected and symptoms initially resemble common respiratory illnesses.

Clinical-response capacity is the second requirement. This includes hospitals equipped to manage surges in cases, PPE and medical supply chains, clinicians, and access to intensive care and supportive treatment. With Ebola, authorities demonstrated a comparatively mature and specialised clinical-response system, largely a result of years of investment and experience. The Hantavirus outbreak revealed strong downstream hospital care but weaker front-end preparedness, particularly in recognising and managing an unexpected pathogen in an unusual setting.

Risk communication and the building of public trust were more effective in the case of Ebola because global public-health systems have spent years developing communication frameworks around it. The Hantavirus outbreak demonstrated how rapidly uncertainty and novelty can destabilise public understanding. At the same time, misinformation has not been completely absent from the Ebola response, underlining the need for strategies to sustain public trust. The Ebola response illustrates how pre-

vious crises can create enduring scientific infrastructure. The Hantavirus, in contrast, has highlighted the difficulties of rapidly organising research around a relatively rare and less continuously funded pathogen. Coordination becomes more difficult when the contagion, its transmission setting and the governance structures involved are unfamiliar. However, even the experience of dealing with Ebola has not eliminated persistent challenges. Reports continue to emerge of shortages of PPE and disinfection materials. The Hantavirus, meanwhile, exposed vulnerabilities associated with international travel environments. Ebola governance systems continue to face political tensions and resource constraints.

The Hantavirus outbreak also revealed how many zoonotic pathogens still lack deeply developed preparedness ecosystems, particularly for unusual scenarios. It was managed largely through broader infectious-disease capacity rather than through dedicated long-term systems. Containing a disease requires a systemic approach. Success depends less on any single intervention and more on how rapidly surveillance, science, healthcare delivery, governance and public communication can function together. Covid triggered a surge in global health funding, much of it emergency-driven and insufficiently institutionalised. Since 2024-25, however, this support has declined sharply, driven in large part by cuts in US aid and the weakening of global institutions such as the WHO.

Global preparedness remains strongest against crises the world has repeatedly confronted — Ebola — and weakest against novel events such as the Hantavirus. Over time, preparedness has become deeper. It must now become broader. Yet developments since 2025 do not inspire confidence. Since Covid, awareness of pandemic risk has increased. Yet political willingness to finance preparedness has weakened. The world is scientifically more capable but financially and politically less stable in sustaining preparedness systems. If not addressed, the next outbreak involving an unusual pathogen could unfold very differently from what happened aboard MV *Hondius*.

The writer is a virologist and chair of Ignite Life Science Foundation (India)

The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, JUNE 11, 2026

*Economic story is
one of transition.
Challenges exist,
but so do strengths*



SOUMYA KANTI GHOSH

IN TWO recent articles, Surjit Bhalla argues that the weakening of reforms, declining investor confidence, and the revised BIT framework signal a loss of economic momentum. While the concerns raised deserve attention, the conclusions drawn are neither fully supported by evidence nor reflective of the broader economic reality.

First, any analysis of economic performance must account for global shocks. When crisis years are excluded, India's average GDP growth during 2005-2014 stands at approximately 7.2 per cent, compared to nearly 7.4 per cent during 2014-2024, achieved despite Covid, supply-chain disruptions, geopolitical conflicts, and tightening global financial conditions. The evidence suggests considerable resilience in India's growth trajectory despite far more adverse external conditions.

Second, the assumption that BITs are the primary drivers of FDI is not supported by global evidence. A major 2014 UNCTAD study covering 146 economies over 27 years found no conclusive evidence that BITs significantly increase bilateral FDI inflows.

Third, investment decisions are shaped by larger factors. The G20 Investment Report (2020) found that investor protection ranked only 10th among decision-influencing factors. Political stability, market size, infrastructure quality, and long-term growth prospects remain the principal determinants. India continues to hold strong advantages across these dimensions.

Fourth, India's own FDI experience does not support the claim that the revised BIT framework has weakened investor confidence. FDI inflows have remained robust even after the 2015 restructuring of India's BIT regime and the subsequent decline in the number of BITs in force. Gross FDI inflows were around \$95 billion in 2025-26. If BIT protections alone determined investment decisions, such sustained inflows would have been difficult to explain. While net FDI is desirable from a balance of payments perspective, a lower number should not be interpreted as weakening investor confidence. As economies mature and integrate with global markets, profit repatriation by foreign firms and overseas investments by domestic companies increase. Lower net FDI figures do not establish that investors have lost confidence in India. India's BIT reforms should therefore be viewed not as a retreat

from reform, but as an effort to balance investor rights with the state's legitimate regulatory interests.

Fifth, international comparison overlooks certain realities. Brazil refrained from ratifying traditional BITs containing Investor-State Dispute Settlement (ISDS) provisions but remained among Latin America's largest FDI destinations. South Africa, Indonesia, Ecuador, and Bolivia also revisited or terminated investment treaties over concerns about sovereign policy flexibility.

Long-term investment confidence is shaped by economic fundamentals, not arbitration clauses alone. India's approach reflects a wider global reassessment.

Sixth, investors are only required to first pursue domestic legal remedies for a specified period before bringing an international claim against the sovereign state. This reflects the well-established principle in customary international law. Arbitration under India's Model BIT remains international in character, conducted before neutral arbitral tribunals, not Indian domestic courts.

Seventh, concerns regarding the rupee must be viewed through the lens of macroeconomic fundamentals. It has depreciated by 10.6 per cent in FY26 – a much sharper move than what the broad dollar strength alone can explain. Context matters. The current account deficit is expected to remain manageable at around 2 per cent of GDP in FY27 and the RBI holds substantial foreign exchange reserves. Despite cumulative RBI foreign currency sales of around \$53 billion in FY26, India's forex reserves were at \$682 billion by April 2026, providing import cover for nearly 11 months. Recent steps taken are positive for the rupee.

We must resist the flawed narrative that the rupee's depreciation is the delayed consequence of the RBI's earlier exchange rate management of holding it back. That is not supported by data. Periods of depreciation have been accompanied by reserve depletion as the RBI intervened to defend the currency. It is remarkable that over a period of nearly 25 years, the average annual depreciation of the rupee has been similar across episodes. This is exchange rate management of the highest order. Pandering to the whims of markets allows market players to dictate terms to the central bank by taking positions for their own benefit. The argument about the rupee being a shock absorber is the easiest way of allowing a limitless fall in the value of the currency, completely delinked from macro fundamentals. India's economic story is one of transition. Challenges exist, but so do strengths. Public debate on economic policy must remain grounded in evidence.

The writer is member, PMEAC, member, 16th Finance Commission and group chief economic advisor, State Bank of India. Views are personal

SHIVKUMAR KALYANARAMAN
AND KISHORE PAKNIKAR

IN TODAY'S world, scientific capability is closely linked with economic competitiveness, technological sovereignty, public health, sustainability, national security, and long-term resilience. India's future will depend not only on what it manufactures but also on what it discovers. Research and innovation remain outside the active imagination of large sections of industry, philanthropy, CSR ecosystems, and society at large. This gap deserves more attention.

Historically, India's expenditure on R&D

as a percentage of GDP has remained modest compared to technologically advanced economies. Funding has traditionally relied heavily on government support. This is not because India lacks social commitment. In fact, India has built one of the world's largest CSR ecosystems and possesses a deep tradition of philanthropy. The problem is that research and innovation are still seen as someone else's responsibility. Research and innovation are not alternatives to social investment — they are force multipliers.

Every modern technology that society today takes for granted was once an uncertain research idea pursued in a laboratory somewhere. Society experiences the visible outcomes but rarely notices the invisible scientific journeys behind them. Research is therefore a form of invisible national infra-

structure. Its returns are often delayed, unpredictable, and difficult to quantify immediately, but their eventual societal impact can be enormous. Nations that consume technology without investing sufficiently in its creation risk becoming dependent on external innovation ecosystems, external intellectual property, and external strategic choices. Scientific capability is deeply linked to economic independence, geopolitical resilience, industrial competitiveness, and na-

**The returns of research are often
delayed and difficult
to quantify immediately, but
their eventual societal impact
can be enormous**

tional confidence. The idea of ANRF is not just to distribute grants, but to catalyse partnerships among government, academia, industry, start-ups, philanthropy, and society.

Strategic co-investment in research often stimulates substantially larger downstream investments within companies themselves. Every rupee co-invested through such partnerships can potentially catalyse several-fold higher internal R&D investments within participating organisations. This is significant because innovation ecosystems rarely grow through isolated grants alone. They grow when research begins to trigger wider institutional confidence, industrial participation, risk-taking, and scientific ambition. Participation need not always begin with massive investments. Companies can support targeted translational projects aligned with na-

tional priorities. Philanthropic foundations can help create doctoral fellowships, advanced instrumentation facilities, interdisciplinary research centres, or regional innovation clusters. Industry associations can co-create challenge-driven innovation programmes. Successful start-ups can reinvest in deep-technology ecosystems that create the next generation of innovation.

The vision of an innovation-driven India will ultimately depend on how successfully the country can transform science from the responsibility of a few institutions into a wider societal movement.

Kalyanaraman is CEO, Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF), Government of India, Paknikar is ANRF Prime Minister Professor, COEP Technological University, Pune

Workers' remittances cross \$100 billion in FY26, but long-term BoP solution needed

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 10

DESPITE THE capital outflows from financial markets and subdued net foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows, India managed to record a Balance of Payments (BoP) surplus of \$7.22 billion in the January-March 2026 quarter, aided by a factor thought to be at risk from the ongoing war in West Asia: remittances from abroad.

In the first quarter of 2026, Indians working abroad sent home \$31.07 billion — the most in 13 years, as per Reserve Bank of India (RBI) data — registering a year-on-year growth of 34%.

But what is more striking is the annual figure.

A new record

In 2025-26 as a whole, Indian workers abroad sent back home a record \$110.47 billion, up 26% from \$87.55 billion in 2024-25, with economists theorising the West Asia crisis probably led to a 'precautionary' rise in remittances.

This is the first time that workers' remittances have ever crossed the \$100-billion-mark in a single year.

The more widely quoted remittances number — which has been above \$100 billion for four years in a row now — is, in fact, not remittances as we think of them, but a broader category called 'private transfers'. While workers' remittances make up more than two-third of private transfers, this category also includes withdrawals from non-resident deposits and their redemption, personal gifts and donations (including to religious and charitable institutions in India),



and gold and silver brought through passenger baggage. Private transfers rose 15% in 2025-26 to \$151.71 billion, while net transfers (after adjusting for money sent abroad) was up 16% at \$144.07 billion.

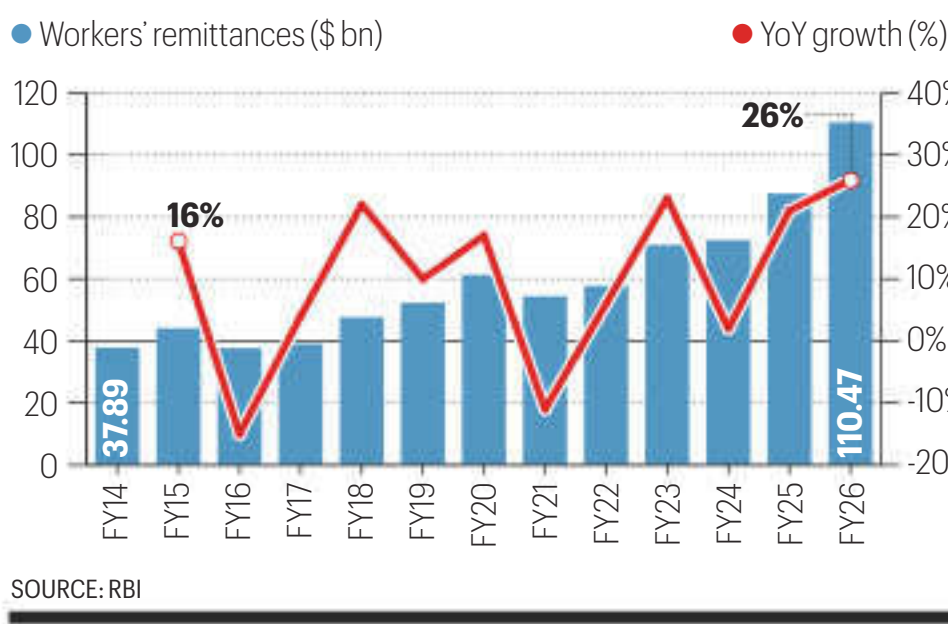
Mutual benefits

In addition to the war, the rupee's sharp fall over the course of 2025-26 would have also incentivised the sending of more dollars (or any other currency) back home than usual as it would lead to family members in India getting more rupees for each unit of the foreign currency.

"Thankfully, remittances have not been adversely affected. And there are no indications they have been (post March)," a senior government official said on Tuesday.

One must indeed be thankful for such strong workers' remittances at a time when the inflow of other types of foreign money has dried up alarm-

Indian workers remitted record \$110 bn into India in FY26



SOURCE: RBI

ingly, be it foreign portfolio investment (FPI) or FDI. If not for these remittances, the rupee may have fallen even more.

Shifting sands of remittances

The West Asia war presented a new hurdle for India's external balance because of the number of Indians working in the region. However, as per the RBI's latest survey on remittances, inflows from the Gulf countries of UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Qatar, Oman and Bahrain had declined to 38% of the total in 2023-24 from 47% in 2016-17. As such, while this means that any hit from the war may not be as large as it would have been before, any benefit from a greater number of Indians being employed once reconstruction efforts begin will also be limited.

The fall in the Gulf regions' share in India's inward remittances has been matched by an

increase in contribution from advanced countries such as the US and the UK — regions grappling with the impact of increasing adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) on current and future employment.

A long-term solution

Remittances, however, cannot be relied upon to bail out the Indian economy. FDI and FPI inflows must improve, while the trade deficit will have to be managed. And although the government is not done announcing measures, it knows its hands are tied beyond a point. "When it comes to gold, nothing we do is enough," government sources said. "People want gold for lots of reasons like traditions, weddings, and investment. We can only provide a nudge, like the Prime Minister had done."

FDI inflows — which totalled less than \$9 billion in 2024-25 and 2025-26 combined on a net basis — are another difficult subject as it has been on

the decline — as a percentage of GDP — since 2010.

"I am not sure if any one step will address the FDI issue," the aforementioned government source said.

"Yes, steps are required. We will take them steadily."

While gross FDI inflows into India rose to a new all-time high of \$94.53 billion in 2025-26, net inflows were a mere \$7.65 billion due to foreign investors repatriating \$53.58 billion and overseas FDI by Indian companies increasing to \$33.29 billion. As such, despite record gross inflows, the net FDI figure has been low in the past two years. For the time being, the measures already announced — from the removal of taxes on foreign investors' bond investments to the swap scheme for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits and PSUs' foreign loans — have materially changed the outlook for the rupee, with the BoP expected to be roughly neutral in 2026-27.

Economists broadly see the rupee hovering around the 94-96-per-dollar levels, with the RBI expected to discourage any strengthening as it mops up as much of foreign inflows it can to build up its foreign exchange reserves. "Nonetheless, the current account deficit remains heavily oil-driven and oil prices remain elevated. We think importers may use the dip in US-DINR (exchange rate) to buy more USD cheaply. Moreover, India's relatively low real yield means that yield-seeking investors are unlikely to be as strongly attracted in the current environment," Barclays' forex strategists Mitul Kotecha and Audrey Ong said in a note on Tuesday.

● **TABLE 5 HAS A SERIES OF CONTROLS DESIGNED TO PREVENT USERS FROM ACCESSING THE MODEL'S DANGEROUS CAPABILITIES**

Why Anthropic has released a Mythos version despite risks

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 10

JUST TWO months ago, Anthropic publicly warned that its most advanced AI system, Claude Mythos Preview, was too risky for a general release.

The company argued that the model had demonstrated an unprecedented ability to discover and exploit software vulnerabilities, raising fears that it could accelerate cyberattacks if widely deployed.

Access was restricted to a small group of trusted organisations through its Project Glasswing programme, which included governments, cybersecurity firms and critical infrastructure operators.

Now, Anthropic has changed

course, at least partially. It has unveiled Claude Fable 5, a publicly available model built on the same underlying "Mythos-class" architecture. The move has prompted an obvious question: if Mythos was considered too dangerous for the public in April, why is a version of it being released in June?

WHAT MADE MYTHOS SO CONCERNING?

Mythos is part of a new generation of large AI systems that sit above Anthropic's existing flagship models in terms of reasoning, coding ability and problem-solving.

Internally described as a "step change" in capability, the system is designed to analyse software, understand complex codebases and identify security



AI firm has unveiled Claude Fable 5, a publicly available model built on the same underlying 'Mythos-class' architecture. REUTERS

weaknesses with minimal human supervision. Anthropic has previously claimed that Mythos was able to find severe vulnerabilities in "every major operating system and web browser", including one that had gone undetected for nearly three dec-

ades.

The model has spooked policymakers worldwide, including in India, as they saw it as a threat to critical infrastructure such as energy and banking.

Earlier this year, the UK AI Security Institute (AISI), in its evalu-

ation of Anthropic's Claude Mythos Preview, flagged a marked jump in cyber capability, especially in structured testing environments.

SO WHAT HAS CHANGED WITH ANTHROPIC'S FABLE 5?

The key difference is not the underlying intelligence of the model, but the safeguards wrapped around it.

Anthropic says Fable 5 uses the same Mythos-class foundation but introduces a series of controls designed to prevent users from accessing the model's most dangerous capabilities. In particular, requests related to sensitive cybersecurity or biological domains are filtered. When the system detects a potentially high-risk query, it automatically routes the user to a less capable

model rather than allowing the request to be handled by the full Mythos-level system. "We've therefore launched the model with safeguards that mean queries on some topics will instead receive a response from our next-most-capable model, Claude Opus 4.8. To release the model both safely and quickly, we've tuned these safeguards conservatively—they'll sometimes catch harmless requests, though they trigger, on average, in less than 5% of sessions. With more capable models arriving in the coming months, we're working to improve our safeguards and reduce false positives as quickly as we can," Anthropic said in a blog post.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 10

These are essential medicines whose prices are controlled by the NPPA under its Drug Prices Control Order 2013. This order essentially allows companies manufacturing these important drugs to raise its price only once a year as per the increases in wholesale prices.

Oncologists from across the country had raised alarm that the commonly used drugs were not available in pharmacy shelves, with cancer patients running from one retailer or wholesaler to the other in search of the medicine.

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, June 10

The HKH Monsoon Outlook 2026, warned that lower rainfall and warmer conditions will also likely intensify heat stress and reduce water availability. The outlook is also crucial for administrative management as winter snow persistence (the time snow

The Hindu Kush Himalaya region

The HKH region is a mountain arc stretching 3,500 km across Afghanistan, Pakistan, Nepal, India, China, Bangladesh, Myanmar and Bhutan. Home to thousands of glaciers and large river basins such as Ganga, Indus, Brahmaputra, Yangtze, Irrawady, Mekong and Amu Darya, they support the food and livelihood security of about two billion people in this region of Asia.

remains on the ground) in the season that passed was below long-term average. “Lower snow persistence means the region is entering the monsoon with a reduced seasonal water buffer,” said Sarthak Shrestha, co-author of the outlook.

This means that communities across the region will depend more on rainfall, groundwater and spring water

At the heart of this year's bleak forecast is the anticipated return of El Niño. El Niño phenomenon is characterised by unusually warm sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern tropical Pacific ocean, which disrupts global weather patterns, including suppression of monsoon in the Indian sub-continent.

Multiple seasonal forecasting agencies — including the South Asian Climate Outlook Forum (SASCOF-34), the Asia-

Forum (ASCOF-07), the Asia Pacific Economic Cooperation Climate Centre, Copernicus Climate Change Service, and the International Research Institute for Climate and Society, have all projected conditions in the Pacific Ocean transitioning from neutral to El Niño during the early monsoon period, with